Dear White America and 'Cuz He's Black

By Danez Smith and Javon Johnson

INTRODUCTION

This is what I want to say: Dear White America, Look deep, look into your souls with silence, quiet that voice that will speak to you of your white "innocence." Take a deep breath. Make a space for my voice in the deepest part of your psyche. Try to listen, to practice being silent. There are times when you must quiet your own voice to hear from or about those who suffer in ways that you do not. Dear White America by Danez Smith.

DEAR WHITE AMERICA

I've left Earth in search of darker planets, a solar system that revolves too near a black hole. I've left a patch of dirt in my place and many of you won't know the difference, giving my name, if it makes you feel better while you run your hands through its soiled scalp.

4NG Fanatics

I've left in search of a new God. **I do not trust the God you have given us.** My grandmother's hallelujah is only outdone by the fear she nurses each time the blood fat summer swallows another child who used to sing in the choir. Take your God back. Though his songs are beautiful, *his miracles are inconsistent.*

I want the fate of Lazarus for Renisha, I want Chucky, Bo, Mo, Trah, Shah, and Islah and Trayvon risen 3 days after their entombing, their ghosts re-gifted flesh and blood, their flesh and blood re-gifted their children.

I have left Earth. I am equal parts sick of your "go back to Africa's as I am your "I just don't see races." *Neither did the poplar tree.*

We did not build your boats, though we did leave a trail of kin to guide us home. **We did not build your prisons, though we did, and we filled them too.** We did not ask to be part of your America, though are we not America,

her bones brittle and dragging a ripped gown through Oakland?

I will not stand your ground. **I am sick of calling this recklessness the law.**

Each night I count my brothers and, in the morning, when some did not survive to be counted, I count the holes they leave your master. Magic trick, America. Now he's breathing, now he don't. Abracadaver, white bread voodoo. Your rope-burned hands, tired of the noose, and my cousin epistled to do your work.

I tried, white people. I tried to love you all, but you spent my brother's funeral making plans for brunch, talking too loud next to his bones. You took one look at the river, plump with the body of boy after boy after sweet boy and asked, "Why does it always have to be about race?" *Because you made it that way.*

4NG Fanatics

Put an asterisk next to my sister's gorgeous face, called her pretty for a black girl, because **black girls go missing without a whisper of where**, because there are no Amber Alerts for the amber-skinned girls, because Jordan boomed, because Emmett whistled, because Huey P spoke it, because Martin preached it, because black boys have always been too loud to live, because it's taken my father's time, my mother's time, my aunts' and my uncles' time, my sisters' and my brothers' time, how much time do you want for your progress?

I have left Earth and I won't stop 'til I find a place where my kin can be safe, until black people ain't but people the same color as the good wet earth, until that means something.

Until then, I bid you well, I bid you war, I bid you our lives to gamble with no more. I have left Earth, and I am touching everything you beg your telescopes to show you, giving the stars their right names in this new

testament, this new story you cannot see or ruin this, if only this one is ours.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Danez Smith
Book: The BreakBeat Poets: New American Poetry in the Age of Hip-Hop (Page 258)
ISBN: 978-1608463954
Publisher: Haymarket Books
Date (Month/Year): April 2015

TRANSITION

Ntozake Shange once wrote that "cuz he's black and poor he's disappeared – the name was lost"

This is what I want to say: Dear White America: Again, take a deep breath. Don't tell me about how many black friends you have. Don't tell me that you voted for Obama. Don't tell me that you don't see color. Don't tell me that I'm blaming whites for everything. To do so is to hide yet again.

You are part of a system that allows you to NOT engage in "the talk" that black people must have with their children. The "talk" about what to do when they are confronted by white police officers." 'Cuz He's Black by Javon Johnson

4NG Fanatics

'CUZ HE'S BLACK

So I'm driving down the street with
my 4-year-old nephew.
He, knocking back a juice
box, me, a Snapple, today y'all
we are doing manly shit. I love
watching the way his mind works.
He asks a million questions.
Uncle, why is the sky blue?
Uncle, how do cars go?
Uncle, why don't dogs talk?
Uncle, uncle, uncle, he asks,
uncle, uncle, uncle, he asks
uncle uncle uncle
as if his voice box is
a warped record. I try my best
to answer every question, I do.
I say it's because the way
the sun lights up the outer space.
It's because engines

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

make the wheels go.
It's because their minds aren't
quite like ours. I say Yes.
No. No. Yes. No. Yes. No. I don't know.
Who knows? Maybe. We laugh.
He smiles at me, looks out the window,
spots a cop car, drops his seat
and says,
"Oh man, Uncle, 5-0, we gotta hide."
I'll be honest. I'm not happy
with the way we raise our Black boys.
Don't like the fact that
he learned to hide
from the cops before
he knew how to read.
Angrier that his survival
depends more on
his ability to deal
with the "authorities"
than it does his own literacy.
"Get up," I yell at him. "In this car, in this family,

4N6 Fanatics

we are not afraid
of the law."
I wonder if he can hear
the uncertainty in my voice.
Is today the day he learns
that uncle is willing to lie to him,
that I am more human
than hero?
We both know the truth
is far more complex than
do not hide. We both know too many
Black boys who disappeared.
Names lost.
Know too many Trayvon Martins
Oscar Grants
and Abner Louimas, know too many
Sean Bells, and Amadou Diallos
Know too well that we are
the hard-boiled sons of Emmett Till.
Still, we both know
it's not about whether or not

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

the shooter is racist,
it's about how poor Black boys
are treated as problems
well before we are treated as people.
Black boys in this country
cannot afford
to play cops and robbers
if we're always considered the latter,
don't have the luxury
of playing war
when we're already in one.
Where I'm from,
seeing cop cars drive
down the street feels a lot
like low-flying planes in New York
City. Where I'm from, routine traffic
stops are more like mine
fields, any wrong move
could very well mean your life.
And how do I look my nephew in his apple face
and tell him to be strong when we both know

4NG Fanatics

black boys are murdered every day, simply
for standing up for themselves? I take him
by the hand, I say
be strong. I say be smart. Be kind, and polite.
Know your laws. Be aware of
how quickly your hands move
to pocket for wallet or ID,
be more aware of how quickly
the officer's hand moves to holster, for gun.
Be Black. Be a boy and have fun,
because this world will force you to
become a man much quicker
than you need to.
"Uncle," he asks, "what happens
if the cop is really mean?"
And, it scares me to
know that he, like
so many Black boys,
is getting ready for a war
I can't prepare him for.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

4NG Fanatics

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Javon Johnson
Book: Viral
ISBN: 978-0989641517
Publisher: Button Poetry
Date (Month/Year): Dec 2013

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY